

These particular 855 million folks have been known to get up to some pretty savvy financial tricks.

Say we're just smarter than the average American. That gives us only 133 million people we need to outwit. And we understand the domestic marketplace. We know all about business in America. Or do we? Consider this item from a November 1997 issue of *Newsweek*: "Tattooing emerged as the country's sixth-fastest growing retail business last year—after Internet and paging services and bagel, computer and cellular phone shops."

What can we do? Well, we can save. One thousand dollars placed in the bank at 5% interest when we graduated from college will be worth \$132,000—by the time we're 122. Or we can spend it all. Somebody will take care of us. Our kids . . . maybe not our kids. But the whole baby boom is planning to retire in the next twenty years. And old people vote like the dickens. Politicians aren't going to allow the Social Security system to collapse any time soon. Besides, no person in America is going to let nice, clean old people (neatly dressed in Hilfiger and Versace from our spendthrift days) starve—unless that person is related to us.

But unfortunately, the best way for we ordinary people to make money is probably by working—doing what we already know how to do, trying to do it better and hoping to get paid more for doing it. The correct investment advice is for us to work ourselves to death. Then we won't care about money. This is the course of action that John Rothchild took (though not, mercifully, to the point of demise). He may have lost money by investing, but, by working on *A Fool and His Money*, he produced an excellent book—and made some money.

Still, work just seems like so much, you know, *work*. So, for our sake, John selflessly tried almost all the other money management strategies.

Now we know that we can buy a CD where we can earn a little money by loaning cash to a bank which turns the cash into a mortgage and earns a lot of money by loaning it back to us.

Or we can buy stocks. Instead of somebody paying us a small fee for our money, we pay somebody a large fee to take it. Then a corporation uses that money to develop improved dial telephone technology, pay its executives lavish salaries, and buy real estate in